

GLOBAL MEDIA INSIGHTS

NBA National TV Audience Analysis

*Understanding the drivers of National
NBA television viewership*

Drew Beal
2025-26 NBA Season

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Executive Summary

Matchup Exposure

Games featuring high-exposure teams consistently attract larger national audiences.

Player Availability

Star availability provides additional signal when explaining game-level audience variation.

Media Context

Network and scheduling characteristics help explain differences in national audience.

Predictive Model

A game-level model provides a framework for identifying games that outperform or underperform expectations.

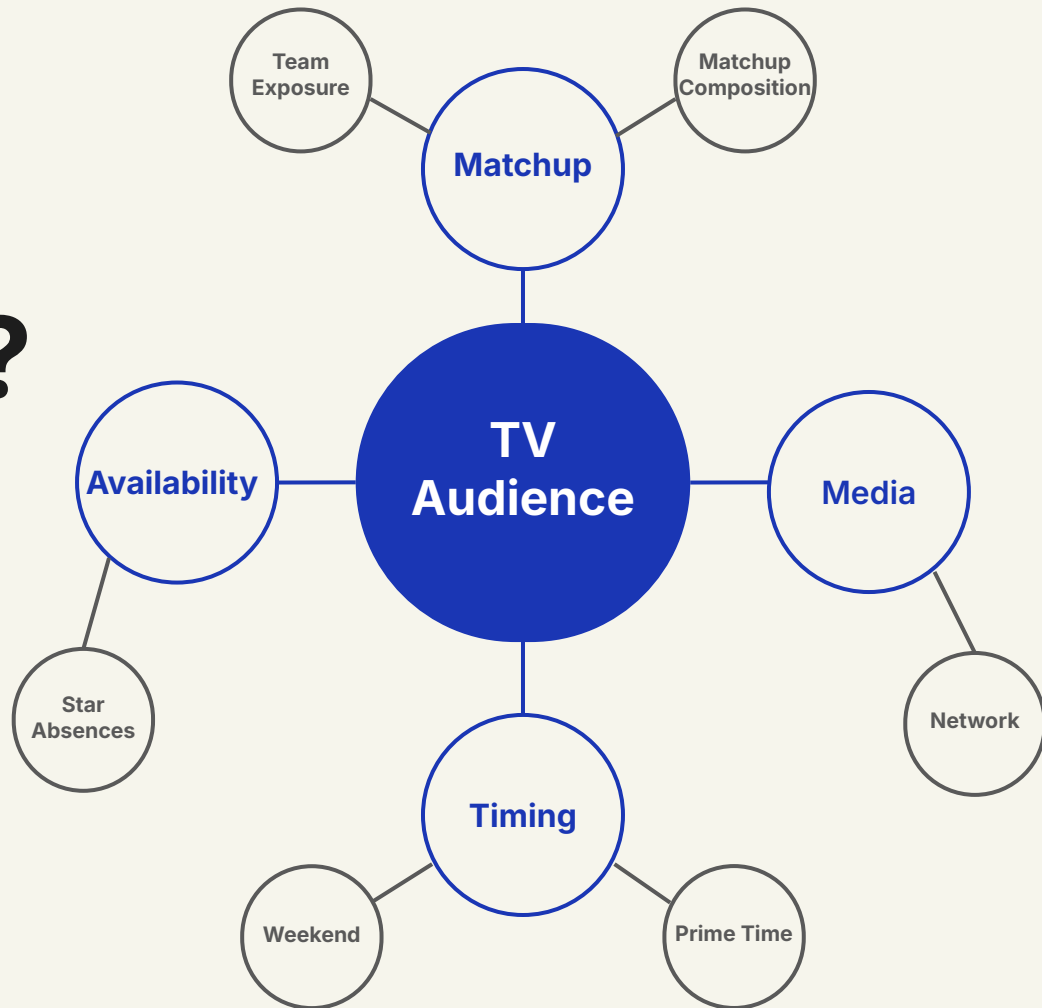
Business Opportunity:

Use historical audience patterns to identify high-potential matchups and investigate games that materially exceed or fall below expected reach.

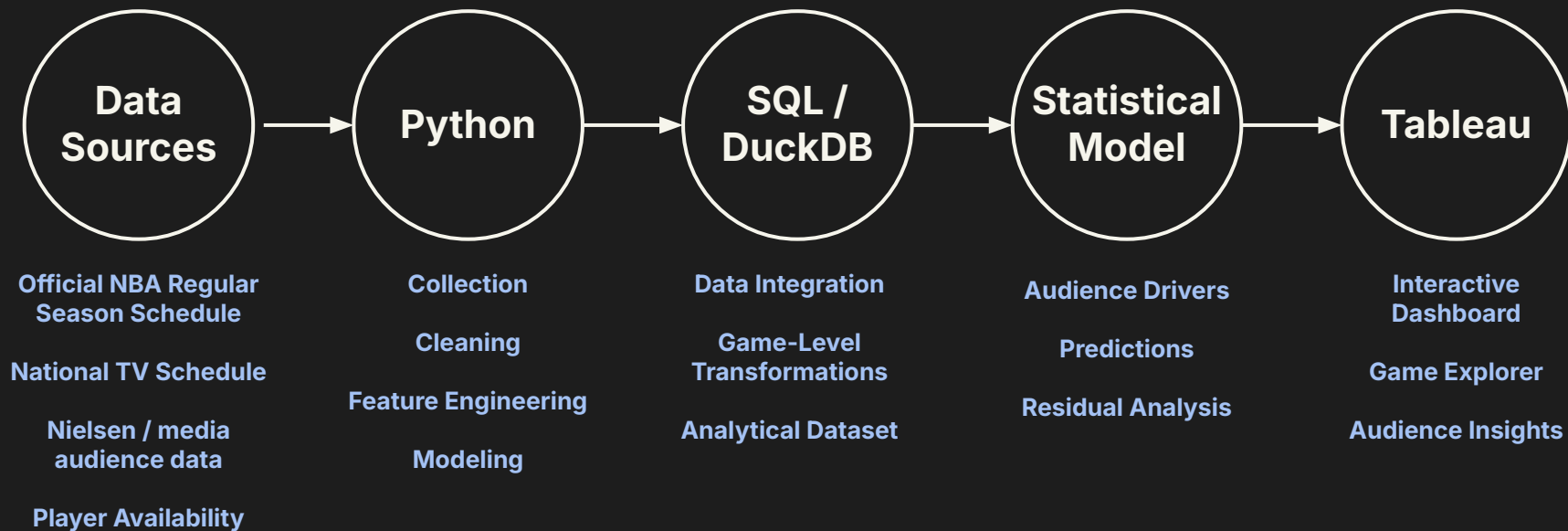
What Drives National NBA TV Audience?

Objective:

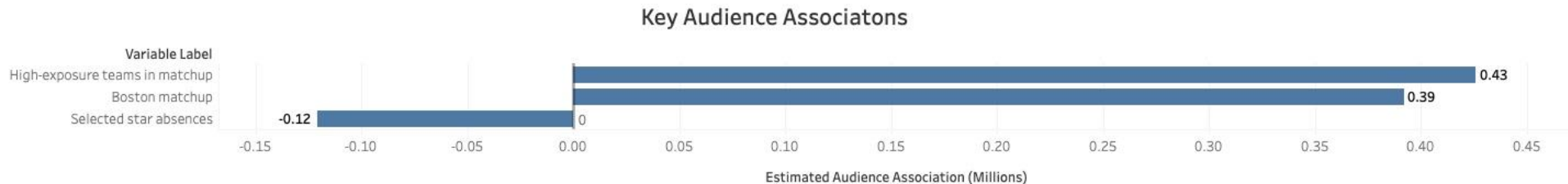
Quantify the strongest audience associations and develop a framework for predicting game-level national audience.



From Raw Media to Audience Insights



Key Audience Associations



Matchup composition and player availability emerge as meaningful audience signals in the 2025–26 sample.

Coefficients represent observational associations from the HC3-robust regression; network and matchup selection are not randomized.

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+0.43M

**Matchup
Exposure**

Each additional “high-exposure” team in the matchup is associated with approximately **426K additional viewers**, holding the other model variables constant.

+0.39M

**Boston
Matchup**

Games involving Boston were associated with approximately **392K additional viewers**, controlling for the other variables in the model.

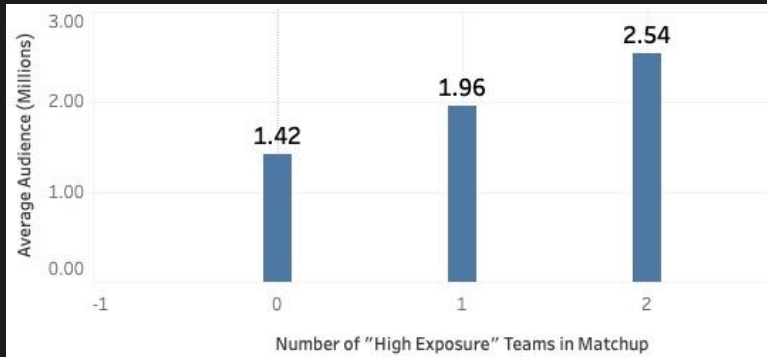
-0.12M

**Star Player
Availability**

Each additional selected star absence was associated with approximately **121K fewer viewers**, all else equal.



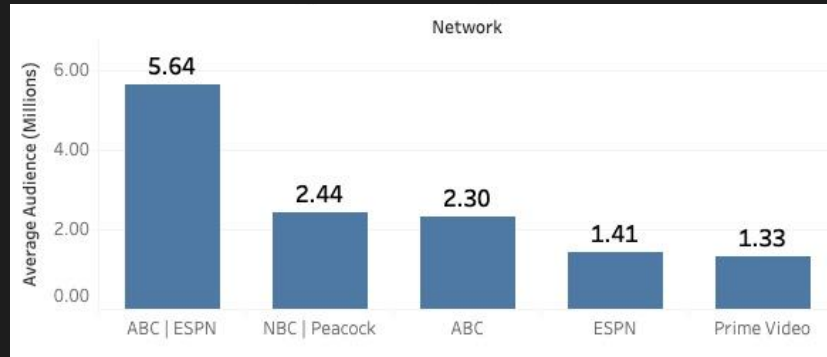
Media & Matchup Insights



Average Audience by Matchup Exposure

Audience increases as more "high-exposure" teams appear in the matchup.

Games featuring two high-exposure teams averaged roughly **2.54M** viewers, compared with **1.42M** when none were involved.



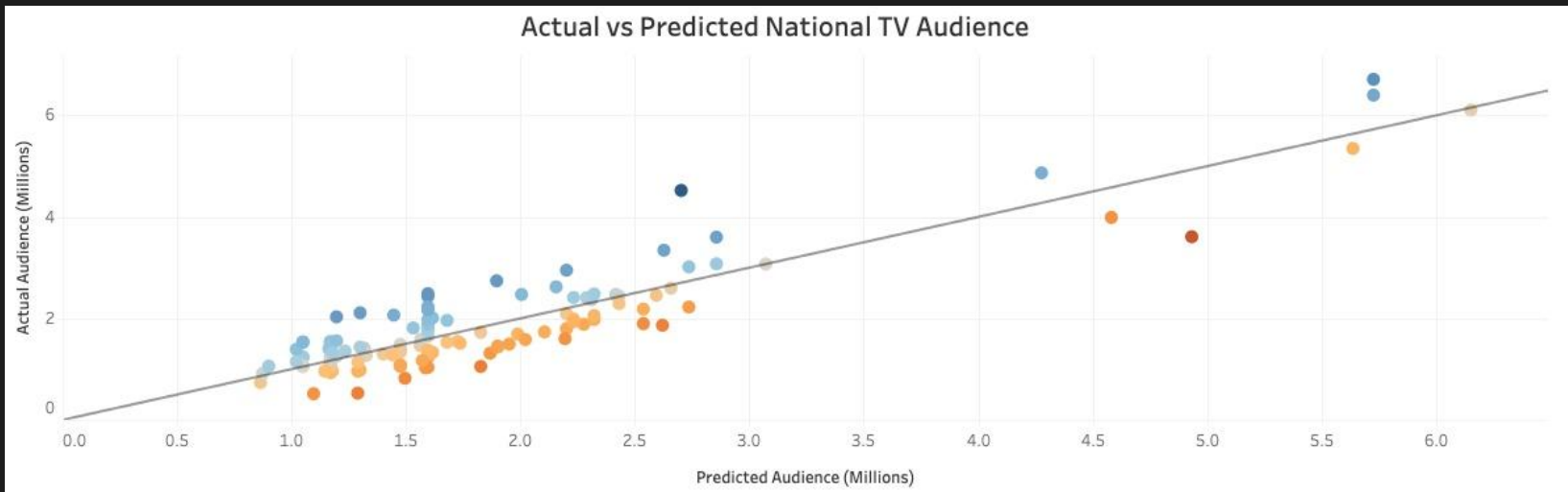
Average Audience by Network

Audience levels vary meaningfully across national networks.

Network differences reflect both the network itself and the types of games selected for each platform. For example, the recorded **ABC | ESPN** games were all **Christmas Day** games.

Can We Predict Audience?

Testing whether game-level audience expectations track actual viewership



0.836

MODEL FIT
 R^2

0.717

OUT OF
SAMPLE FIT
5-Fold CV R^2

0.535M

PREDICTION
ERROR
5-Fold CV RMSE

The model captures substantial variation in national audience, while cross-validation indicates meaningful predictive performance on unseen games.

Residuals highlight games that exceeded or fell below the audience level expected from their matchup, network, timing, and availability characteristics.

Model to Game-Level Insights

An interactive view for investigating individual games and audience performance actuals

Away Team	Home Team	Network	Game Date	Star Absences	
ATL	CLE	ESPN	4/8/2026	0	1.199
	DET	ESPN	3/25/2026	1	1.074
	MIL	ESPN	3/4/2026	0	1.050
BOS	CLE	ABC	3/8/2026	0	2.409
	DEN	ESPN	2/25/2026	1	1.400
	DET	NBC Peacock	1/19/2026	1	1.494
	LAL	NBC Peacock	2/22/2026	1	4.522
	MIA	ESPN	4/1/2026	0	1.464
	NYK	Prime Video	10/24/2025	1	1.170
	PHI	Prime Video	10/31/2025	1	0.961
	MIL	ESPN	2/3/2026	1	1.050
CHI	CLE	ESPN	10/29/2025	1	1.281
	CHA	ESPN	1/21/2026	0	0.931
	DET	ESPN	2/27/2026	1	1.539
	NYK	ABC ESPN	12/25/2025	0	6.400
		ESPN	10/22/2025	0	2.166
	OKC	ABC	2/22/2026	1	2.093
	ORL	ESPN	3/11/2026	0	1.151
	PHI	ESPN	1/14/2026	0	1.196
			1/16/2026	0	1.253
	SAS	NBC Peacock	12/29/2025	0	1.529
DAL	BOS	ESPN	3/6/2026	0	1.692
	GSW	ABC ESPN	12/25/2025	0	6.107
	HOU	ABC	1/31/2026	0	1.933

Network

- ☒ (All)
- ☒ ABC
- ☒ ABC | ESPN
- ☒ ESPN
- ☒ NBC | Peacock
- ☒ Prime Video

Star Absences



Audience (M)



Weekend Game

- ☒ (All)
- ☒ Null
- ☒ No
- ☒ YES

Prime Time Game

- ☒ (All)
- ☒ Null
- ☒ No
- ☒ Yes

01: FILTER

Isolate Games

Explore games by network, matchup, timing, and other model features

02: COMPARE

Benchmark Performance

Compare observed audience with the level expected by the model

03:

INVESTIGATE

Explain Outliers

Identify games that substantially over- or under-performed expectations

The dashboard turns the model from a statistical exercise into an analyst-facing tool for investigating audience performance.

From Audience Analytics to Media Strategy

Strategic
Recommendations

What I'd
Do Next

Prioritize Matchup Exposure

Use historical audience patterns to identify matchups involving high-exposure teams and quantify their expected national reach.

Why it matters: Helps inform scheduling, media planning, and expectations around marquee games.

Expand the Data

- ★ Full-Season Data Sample of Every Nationally Televised Game
- ★ Multi-Season Audience History
- ★ Digital / Social Engagement
- ★ Ratings & Share
- ★ Demographic Audience Data

Account for Player Availability

Adjust audience expectations when selected high-profile players are unavailable.

Why it matters: A marquee matchup can have materially different audience potential depending on who is actually playing

Improve the Model

- ★ Nonlinear Relationships
- ★ Interaction Effects
- ★ More Granular Player/Star Metrics
- ★ Larger Training Sample

Investigate Audience Outliers

Use the model to flag games that substantially outperform or underperform expected audience.

Why it matters: Outliers can reveal emerging matchups, scheduling effects, media opportunities, or additional audience drivers not captured by the current model.

Operationalize

- ★ Automated Game-Level Audience Forecasts
- ★ Pre-game Expected Audience Dashboard
- ★ Post-game Actual vs. Expected Reporting

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Build from historical audience analysis toward a repeatable framework for forecasting, benchmarking, and explaining NBA media performance.